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Free Parent Handbook Template for Daycare Centers (Editable)

Free editable parent handbook template for daycares:
enrollment, drop-off, illness, meals, discipline, emergency, and
communication policies.

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Free editable parent handbook template for daycares: enrollment, drop-off, illness, meals, discipline, emergency, and communication policies.

- ☐ Confirm attendance dates match room records.
- ☐ Mark ratio notes that support licensing review.
- ☐ Attach subsidy claim evidence before filing.
- ☐ Keep guardian and pickup updates with the child record.

Enrollment Policies

Your enrollment section sets expectations before a family commits. When these details are in writing, you avoid awkward conversations about fees or schedules later.

Enrollment requirements:

- Completed enrollment form with child's full legal name, date of birth, and home address
- Emergency contact information for at least two adults other than parents/guardians
- Immunization records current per your state's requirements (or a signed exemption form where permitted)
- Signed medical authorization allowing you to seek emergency treatment
- Allergy and dietary restriction documentation from the child's pediatrician if applicable
- Signed parent handbook acknowledgment (this document)

Enrollment fee:

- A non-refundable enrollment fee of \$_____ is due at the time of enrollment to secure the child's spot
- This fee covers administrative setup, supplies, and curriculum materials for the first month

Trial period:

- The first two weeks of enrollment are a trial period for both the family and the provider
- Either party may end the arrangement during the trial period with 48 hours' notice and no further financial obligation beyond days attended

Withdrawal and termination:

- Families must provide _____ weeks written notice to withdraw a child
- Tuition is due through the end of the notice period regardless of attendance
- The provider reserves the right to terminate enrollment immediately for safety reasons, or with one week's written notice for other reasons including persistent policy violations or non-payment

Schedule and hours:

- Operating hours: _____ AM to _____ PM, Monday through Friday
- Part-time schedules are available for _____ days per week minimum
- A child's enrolled schedule is fixed. Schedule changes require _____ weeks' notice and are subject to availability

Drop-Off and Pick-Up Procedures

Clear drop-off and pick-up rules protect the children in your care and keep your day running on time.

Drop-off:

- Drop-off window: _____ AM to _____ AM
- Parents must escort children inside and sign the daily attendance log (or check in via the parent app)
- Children arriving after the drop-off window may be turned away for the day, as late arrivals disrupt group activities
- If a child will be absent, parents must notify the provider by _____ AM via [text/app/phone]

Pick-up:

- Standard pick-up time: _____ PM
- Late pick-up fee: \$_____ per minute after _____ PM, charged to the next invoice
- Only adults listed on the authorized pick-up list may collect a child
- Anyone not previously known to the provider must present government-issued photo ID, even if they are on the authorized list
- If no authorized person arrives by _____ PM and the provider cannot reach any emergency contact, the provider will contact local authorities

Authorized pick-up list:

- Parents provide the names and phone numbers of all authorized pick-up persons at enrollment
- Changes to the list must be submitted in writing (text or email is acceptable)
- Verbal authorizations by phone are accepted only in emergencies and require confirmation of the parent's identity through a pre-established security question

Custody documentation:

- If a court order restricts a parent's access to the child, the provider must receive a copy of the current court order
- The provider will follow the court order as written and cannot make exceptions based on verbal requests from either parent

Illness Policy

Sick child policies are the most common source of friction between families and providers. Be specific about what requires a child to stay home and when they can return.

A child must stay home if they have:

- Fever of 100.4 F (38 C) or higher, measured orally or with a temporal thermometer
- Vomiting within the past 24 hours (not related to a known non-contagious condition)
- Diarrhea (two or more loose stools within the past 24 hours)
- Undiagnosed rash
- Pink eye (conjunctivitis) with discharge
- Head lice (until treated and nit-free)
- Any communicable disease (hand-foot-mouth, strep, RSV, flu, COVID) until cleared by a physician or symptom-free for the period specified by your state health department

Return-to-care requirements:

- Fever-free for 24 hours without fever-reducing medication
- Vomiting/diarrhea-free for 24 hours
- On antibiotics for at least 24 hours (for bacterial infections)
- Physician's clearance note for communicable diseases

If a child becomes ill during care:

- The provider will isolate the child from the group in a comfortable, supervised area
- Parents will be notified immediately and must arrange pick-up within _____ hour(s)
- If the parent cannot be reached, emergency contacts will be called in order
- Tuition is not credited for sick days

Medication administration:

- The provider will only administer medication with a signed medication authorization form
- Prescription medication must be in the original container with the child's name, dosage, and doctor's name on the label
- Over-the-counter medication requires written authorization specifying the medication name, dosage, and timing
- The provider will document each dose given (time, amount) in the daily log

Meal and Snack Policies

Whether you provide meals or require families to send food, put it in writing.

Provider-supplied meals (if applicable):

- The provider serves breakfast, lunch, and two snacks daily
- Menus are posted weekly via [the parent app / bulletin board / email]
- Meals meet USDA Child and Adult Care Food Program (CACFP) guidelines where applicable
- The provider accommodates documented food allergies with a physician's note on file
- Religious or cultural dietary accommodations are honored with advance written request

Parent-supplied meals (if applicable):

- Parents are responsible for providing a labeled lunch and two labeled snacks daily
- All food must be labeled with the child's name and the date
- Perishable food must arrive in an insulated bag with an ice pack
- The provider will reheat food in a microwave but does not cook meals from raw ingredients
- No foods containing nuts or nut products unless the classroom is certified nut-free

General food rules:

- No candy, soda, or energy drinks
- Birthday treats are permitted with 48 hours' advance notice and must be store-bought with a visible ingredient list (for allergy safety)
- Water is available to children throughout the day

Discipline and Behavior Approach

Parents want to know how you handle behavioral issues. Be honest about your methods and boundaries.

Positive guidance approach:

- Redirection: guiding a child toward appropriate behavior rather than focusing on the unwanted behavior
- Verbal guidance using age-appropriate language
- Giving children choices when possible (“You can play with blocks or draw. Which would you like?”)
- Modeling expected behavior
- Consistent, predictable routines that reduce behavioral triggers

What the provider will never do:

- Corporal punishment of any kind (spanking, hitting, shaking, pinching)
- Withhold food, water, rest, or bathroom access as punishment
- Use demeaning language, yelling, or humiliation
- Isolate a child in a room alone (time-outs are brief, supervised, and age-appropriate)

Persistent behavioral issues:

- If a behavior pattern persists, the provider will schedule a parent conference to discuss observations and collaborate on a consistent approach
- For biting, hitting, or behavior that endangers other children, the provider may require a parent to pick up the child for the remainder of the day
- If a child’s behavior consistently endangers others or requires one-on-one supervision that the provider cannot maintain while caring for the group, the provider may require withdrawal with one week’s notice

Emergency Procedures

Your emergency section should leave no ambiguity about what happens in a crisis.

Medical emergencies:

- The provider will call 911 immediately for any life-threatening situation
- Parents and emergency contacts will be notified as soon as the child is in professional care
- The signed medical authorization on file permits the provider to authorize emergency treatment
- A copy of each child's emergency information and medical authorization travels with the group on all outings

Fire/evacuation:

- The provider conducts fire drills monthly and documents each drill
- Primary exit route: [describe]
- Secondary exit route: [describe]
- Evacuation meeting point: [describe]
- After evacuation, the provider accounts for all children by headcount and attendance roster

Severe weather:

- For tornado warnings: children are moved to [interior room/basement] away from windows
- For power outages lasting more than 2 hours: parents will be notified and may be asked to pick up early
- For flooding or road closures affecting the facility: the provider will communicate closure via [text/app/phone]

Lockdown:

- In the event of a threat near the facility, the provider will lock all doors, move children to an interior room, and contact law enforcement
- Parents will be notified once the situation is resolved
- Parents must not attempt to enter the facility during a lockdown

Emergency supplies on hand:

- First aid kit (inspected monthly)
- Emergency contact binder with printed copies of all children's information
- Flashlights and batteries
- Bottled water and shelf-stable snacks for 24 hours

Communication Expectations

Spell out how and when you communicate. Mismatched communication expectations cause more provider-family tension than almost anything else.

Daily communication:

- Daily reports via [the parent app / written sheet / text] including meals eaten, nap times, diaper changes or bathroom visits, activities, and notable moments
- Reports are sent by pick-up time each day

Ongoing communication:

- The provider responds to non-urgent parent messages within _____ hours during business hours
- Urgent messages (child illness, emergency) receive an immediate response
- The provider does not respond to messages during care hours except for emergencies, as attention is on the children

Conferences:

- Formal parent-provider conferences are offered twice per year (or as needed)
- Developmental observations are shared in writing prior to the conference
- Either party may request an additional conference at any time

Privacy and photos:

- The provider may take photos of children during activities for daily reports and portfolio documentation
- Photos are shared only with the child's parents via [the parent app / secure platform]
- Photos will not be posted on social media without separate written consent from the parent

Holiday and Closure Schedule

List every day your program is closed so families can plan ahead.

Paid holidays (tuition is still due):

- New Year's Day
- Martin Luther King Jr. Day
- Presidents' Day
- Memorial Day
- Independence Day (and the day before or after if it falls mid-week)
- Labor Day
- Thanksgiving Day and the Friday after
- Christmas Eve and Christmas Day
- New Year's Eve (early closure at _____ PM)

Provider personal days:

- The provider takes _____ personal/vacation days per year
- Families will receive at least _____ weeks' notice of planned closures
- Tuition is still due during provider vacation days
- If the provider is unexpectedly ill, families will be notified by _____ AM

Weather closures:

- The provider follows [local school district name] for weather-related closures
- If the school district closes or delays, the provider will communicate the plan by _____ AM
- Tuition is still due for weather closure days

Tuition during closures:

- Tuition is charged on a flat weekly/monthly rate regardless of holidays, closures, or child absences
- This rate reflects the annual cost of care divided evenly across all weeks
- No refunds or credits are given for individual closure days

Fee Schedule and Payment Terms

Leave no room for confusion about what families owe and when.

Tuition rates:

- Full-time (5 days/week): \$_____ per week
- Part-time (3 days/week): \$_____ per week
- Part-time (2 days/week): \$_____ per week
- Infant rates (under _____ months): add \$_____ per week

Payment terms:

- Tuition is due every [Monday / first of the month] for the [current / upcoming] week
- Accepted payment methods: [check, Venmo, Zelle, auto-debit, parent app payment]
- A \$_____ late fee is charged for payments received after [day and time]
- If payment is more than _____ days late, the child's spot may be forfeited

Additional fees:

- Registration fee: \$_____ (one-time, non-refundable)
- Late pick-up: \$_____ per minute after _____ PM
- Returned check/failed payment: \$_____ per occurrence
- Supply fee: \$_____ per [month/quarter] for craft materials, cleaning supplies, etc.

Rate increases:

- The provider may adjust rates annually, effective [January 1 / the anniversary of enrollment]
- Families will receive at least 30 days' written notice of any rate change